

Guide 65 — Recreation Worker and Activities Coordinator

Controlled English working master — Version 2.0

Review date: August 20, 2026

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What this work is

Recreation Workers and Activities Coordinators help plan, organize, communicate, deliver, document, and improve leisure, social, community, wellness, cultural, sports, and group activities. Depending on the employer, the job may involve leading activities directly, arranging schedules and spaces, preparing supplies, registering participants, communicating with families or partners, coordinating volunteers, supporting events, tracking attendance, maintaining program records, and helping keep activities safe and accessible.

The title is not standardized. A **Recreation Worker** may spend much of the day leading or supervising activities. An **Activities Coordinator** may have more responsibility for calendars, logistics, records, volunteers, purchasing, communications, and program administration. Some coordinator jobs approach first-line supervision, while others remain frontline program-support roles. Always compare the actual duties, decision authority, required credentials, participant population, safety obligations, supervision responsibilities, budget authority, and reporting line rather than relying on the title alone.

In the United States, the closest broad official benchmark for frontline recreation work is **O*NET-SOC 39-9032.00 — Recreation Workers**. In Canada, a useful broad comparison is **NOC 54100 — Program leaders and instructors in recreation, sport and fitness**. Neither classification makes every Activities Coordinator job identical to the benchmark.

Typical duties

Depending on the program and your authorized scope, duties may include:

- organizing and leading recreation, leisure, social, cultural, sports, arts, games, outings, or wellness activities;
- preparing activity calendars, schedules, room assignments, equipment, supplies, sign-in materials, and participant communications;
- explaining activity rules and helping participants use equipment safely;

- monitoring participation and escalating hazards, injuries, conflicts, safeguarding concerns, or emergencies through approved procedures;
- supporting registration, attendance, consent, emergency-contact, incident, and routine program records;
- coordinating volunteers, vendors, performers, community partners, transportation providers, facilities, or internal departments;
- adapting communication and activity logistics to support accessible participation;
- collecting participant feedback and helping improve future programming;
- tracking approved supplies, purchase requests, invoices, program expenses, and inventory;
- promoting activities through approved flyers, calendars, email, websites, social media, community partners, or internal communications;
- helping with setup, cleanup, room configuration, equipment storage, and event logistics;
- maintaining factual notes and routine program metrics;
- supporting senior recreation staff, program managers, nurses, educators, therapists, coaches, social-service professionals, or administrators without representing yourself as holding authority you do not have; and
- completing employer-required training for safety, safeguarding, privacy, cybersecurity, transportation, emergency response, or population-specific procedures.

What this role must not be presented as

A Recreation Worker or Activities Coordinator title does not automatically authorize you to:

- practice recreational therapy, physical therapy, occupational therapy, nursing, medicine, psychology, social work, counseling, teaching, athletic training, or another regulated profession;
- diagnose, assess, treat, rehabilitate, prescribe exercise, or make clinical decisions outside an authorized credentialed role;
- act as a lifeguard, aquatic-safety professional, certified coach, fitness professional, or first responder unless the employer requires and verifies the necessary credential and assigns that duty;
- provide unsupervised childcare merely because children participate in a recreation program;
- conduct safeguarding investigations or promise confidentiality that conflicts with law or policy;
- transport participants in a personal or employer vehicle unless the organization has formally authorized the duty and all licensing,

insurance, vehicle, training, and supervision requirements are satisfied;

- approve contracts, purchases, refunds, vendor commitments, restricted funds, grants, or budget changes without delegated authority;
- use participant photographs, names, health information, disability information, emergency contacts, or family information outside approved consent and privacy procedures; or
- treat an AI-generated suggestion, translation, schedule, safety instruction, or participant note as an approved decision without human review.

When authority is unclear, stop and ask the responsible supervisor or designated professional.

Work environments

Recreation and activity staff may work in:

- municipal parks and recreation departments;
- community and senior centers;
- summer camps and after-school programs;
- schools, colleges, and universities;
- resorts, hotels, cruise or tourism settings;
- clubs, sports and recreation facilities;
- residential-care and retirement communities;
- health-care and disability-service organizations;
- nonprofit, faith-based, cultural, and youth organizations;
- correctional or rehabilitation settings;
- outdoor recreation programs; and
- employer wellness or community-engagement programs.

Work may be indoors or outdoors and can include evenings, weekends, holidays, seasonal schedules, field trips, public events, physical setup, standing, walking, lifting within employer limits, and exposure to weather or active environments. BLS notes that recreation workers may have irregular or seasonal schedules and that the occupation has meaningful injury exposure. Follow site-specific safety procedures rather than assuming a recreation setting is low risk.

Skills employers may value

Useful skills often include:

- clear communication and active listening;
- organization and follow-through;

- activity and event planning;
- group facilitation;
- participant service;
- conflict de-escalation;
- professional boundaries;
- calendar and scheduling skills;
- accurate recordkeeping;
- volunteer coordination;
- supply and inventory tracking;
- basic budgeting and expense awareness;
- accessible communication and inclusion;
- teamwork with multidisciplinary staff;
- cultural awareness and respectful service;
- situational awareness and hazard reporting;
- privacy and confidentiality;
- basic cybersecurity habits; and
- judgment about when to stop an activity or escalate a concern.

A warm personality can help, but reliability, safety awareness, documentation, boundaries, and consistent follow-through matter just as much as enthusiasm.

Education and entry pathways

United States

The U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics states that Recreation Workers typically need at least a **high school diploma or equivalent**, although requirements vary by position, and that short-term on-the-job training is common after hire.

Some employers may accept high school education plus relevant experience in camps, parks, customer service, community programs, sports, arts, senior programs, youth programs, volunteering, or events. Other employers—especially for coordinator jobs in residential care, higher education, specialized programs, or roles with greater planning responsibility—may prefer an associate or bachelor's degree in recreation, leisure studies, sports management, community recreation, education, human services, gerontology, event management, public administration, or a related field.

BLS notes that some employers require certifications such as CPR or first aid. Requirements depend on the job. Aquatic, fitness, coaching, driving, childcare, clinical, outdoor-adventure, or specialized sports duties may require additional credentials and employer training.

A practical entry sequence is:

1. Review 15–20 current local job postings using titles such as recreation worker, recreation leader, activities assistant, activities coordinator, program aide, recreation coordinator, camp counselor, community recreation leader, or senior-living activities assistant.
2. Record recurring requirements for education, age, schedule, driving, background checks, CPR/first aid, languages, computer skills, lifting, outdoor work, participant population, and supervision.
3. Separate true requirements from preferences.
4. Build transferable experience through volunteering, community programs, events, customer service, camps, sports, arts, schools, senior programs, disability-inclusive programs, or municipal recreation.
5. Use free or low-cost public training to close specific gaps before paying for a broad private credential.
6. Apply only to duties you can perform safely and honestly within your training and authority.

Canada

Government of Canada Job Bank places **Program leaders and instructors in recreation, sport and fitness** in **NOC 54100**. Job Bank currently states that this occupation usually requires a **secondary school diploma or several weeks of on-the-job training**.

NOC 54100 is useful when the job involves leading or instructing recreation programs. An Activities Coordinator title may include more administration, volunteer coordination, senior-living programming, event work, or supervision, so confirm the exact NOC fit from duties rather than title alone.

Provincial, employer, facility, child-protection, driving, first-aid, aquatic, fitness, or population-specific requirements may add qualifications beyond the national occupational summary.

Colombia

Current public evidence shows multiple SENA pathways related to recreation and physical activity.

SENA Betowa currently lists **Liderazgo en la actividad deportiva y la recreación**, a **40-hour** in-person complementary special course. Current 2026 offerings demonstrate that this is an active public-training pathway, but it is a short skill-development course and is not a universal occupational license or substitute for a technical or technological program.

A 2026 Bogotá Secretaría de Cultura, Recreación y Deporte–SENA agreement includes **Tecnólogo en Actividad Física**, with learning related to physical-activity programs, recreation, group activities, wellness, community settings, and safe exercise. An official SCRD program page lists

this technologist pathway at **3,520 hours**. Verify the current cohort, curriculum, duration, admission requirements, and location before enrolling.

SENA also reported in May 2026 on learners in **Técnico en Ejecución de Programas Deportivos**, including exposure to recreation models and sports-sector institutions. These examples show a public training ecosystem; they do not mean every recreation or activities job requires the same credential.

Latin America and the Caribbean

Training systems and job titles vary widely. **OIT/Cinterfor** provides regional vocational-training information and a statistics observatory that can help identify the national public training institution in a country.

Use the regional locator first, then verify the exact program, recognition, cost, entry requirements, schedule, safety content, and employer relevance directly with the national institution.

Free-first and low-cost training strategy

Before paying for training:

1. Review real job postings in your target market.
2. Identify the requirements that repeat across employers.
3. Ask employers what training they provide after hire.
4. Prioritize public workforce programs, community colleges, municipal recreation training, libraries, public vocational systems, recognized nonprofit training, and employer-sponsored courses.
5. Compare total cost, transportation, materials, exams, renewals, background checks, placement requirements, and unpaid hours.
6. Verify whether employers actually recognize the credential.
7. Get refund, job-placement, and repayment claims in writing.
8. Avoid debt for a private certificate that target employers do not request.

Useful skill areas may include group facilitation, event planning, customer service, spreadsheets, scheduling, accessibility, volunteer coordination, conflict de-escalation, safeguarding awareness, first aid/CPR where relevant, incident documentation, privacy, cybersecurity, and basic budgeting.

Funding, scholarships, and public training locators

United States

CareerOneStop's **WIOA-Eligible Training Program Finder** links to state directories of training programs that may be considered for WIOA support. Eligibility, local priorities, available funds, and approved programs vary. A program's inclusion does **not** guarantee funding for a specific person.

CareerOneStop's **American Job Center Finder** can help locate free employment and training assistance. Services can include career counseling, job-search help, training referrals, skills assessment, workshops, accessibility accommodations, and information about supportive services.

CareerOneStop also provides training and scholarship search tools. Verify scholarship eligibility and deadlines directly with the sponsor before relying on an award.

Canada

Training support and student aid vary by province or territory, institution, employment program, and individual eligibility. Check current provincial employment services, public colleges, recognized institutions, municipal recreation employers, and employer tuition or certification support before paying privately.

Colombia and Latin America

Start with SENA/Betowa and SENA public employment services in Colombia. In other Latin American countries, use OIT/Cinterfor to identify the relevant national vocational-training institution and then verify current offerings directly.

Apprenticeships and work-based learning

There is no universal Registered Apprenticeship requirement for Recreation Workers. **Apprenticeship.gov** provides a current finder for apprenticeship jobs and programs. Search related keywords and location rather than assuming an apprenticeship exists for this exact title.

Work-based learning may also come from:

- seasonal municipal recreation employment;
- supervised camp work;
- community-center programs;
- youth or senior programs;
- disability-inclusive recreation;
- school or university recreation;

- nonprofit programs;
- parks and outdoor programs;
- sports or arts programs; and
- employer-paid onboarding.

Volunteering can build evidence, but it should not be used as a substitute for paid work when an employer is using volunteers to fill what should be a paid position. Ask about duties, supervision, insurance, background screening, expenses, and training before accepting a placement.

Employer-supported development

Ask employers about:

- paid onboarding;
- site emergency procedures;
- first aid/CPR training where required;
- activity-specific safety training;
- safeguarding and mandatory-reporting procedures;
- background-check reimbursement;
- accessibility and disability-inclusion training;
- de-escalation and behavior-support boundaries;
- participant privacy and records training;
- cybersecurity and phishing awareness;
- scheduling and registration systems;
- volunteer-management training;
- safe lifting or equipment procedures where relevant;
- driver approval and vehicle procedures if transportation is part of the job;
- tuition assistance or certification reimbursement; and
- pathways from aide or leader to coordinator, senior coordinator, supervisor, or program manager.

Get any repayment obligation for employer-funded education in writing.

Compensation and employment outlook

United States — official Recreation Worker benchmark

O*NET currently displays Bureau of Labor Statistics **2025 wage data** for **Recreation Workers, 39-9032.00**:

- **\$17.58 per hour median;**
- **\$36,560 per year median;**
- **approximately 327,700 workers in 2024;**
- **projected growth of 3% to 4% from 2024 to 2034;** and

- approximately **68,100 projected openings per year**.

The BLS Occupational Outlook Handbook currently shows the earlier **May 2024** median of **\$35,380 per year / \$17.01 per hour**, a 4% 2024-2034 growth projection, and about 68,100 annual openings. The wage difference reflects the reference year. Keep the year attached to each figure.

United States — current non-government Recreation Coordinator estimates

Salary.com, as of **August 1, 2026**, reports an average U.S. Recreation Coordinator salary of approximately:

- **\$46,166 per year**;
- approximately **\$22 per hour**; and
- a reported 25th-75th percentile range of about **\$40,212-\$51,090**.

ZipRecruiter, as of **July 27, 2026**, reports an average U.S. Recreation Coordinator estimate of approximately:

- **\$54,391 per year**;
- approximately **\$26.15 per hour**; and
- a reported majority range of about **\$42,000-\$65,500**.

These are **non-government coordinator-title estimates**. Their data sources and title matching differ from official BLS/O*NET statistics. Do not average them together or treat them as guaranteed pay.

Canada — official NOC 54100 comparison

Government of Canada Job Bank reports national wages for a recreation program leader under **NOC 54100**, updated **November 19, 2025** using the 2023-2024 Labour Force Survey reference period:

- **CAD \$15.44/hour low**;
- **CAD \$19.00/hour median**; and
- **CAD \$31.00/hour high**.

Job Bank states that prospects vary across Canada. These figures are a broad NOC 54100 comparison and are not guaranteed Activities Coordinator wages.

Colombia

A directly comparable current national official wage series was not identified that cleanly maps every generic Recreation Worker and Activities Coordinator title. Do not invent a national salary figure.

Use current SENA Agencia Pública de Empleo, municipal recreation agencies, clubs, schools, universities, nonprofit organizations, senior-care

providers, resorts, community programs, sports organizations, and employer postings to compare pay, contract type, schedule, travel, participant population, education, and authority in the city or department where you plan to work.

Safety and emergency boundaries

Recreation work can involve physical activity, equipment, outdoor conditions, crowds, children, older adults, people with disabilities, transportation, pools, fields, gyms, kitchens, stages, craft materials, or unfamiliar venues.

Follow the employer's approved procedures for:

- activity risk assessment;
- participant ratios and supervision;
- equipment inspection and storage;
- weather, heat, cold, air quality, and lightning;
- hydration and rest practices;
- allergies and food restrictions where food is involved;
- emergency contacts;
- evacuation and shelter procedures;
- injury and incident reporting;
- lost-participant or missing-person procedures;
- medication boundaries;
- aquatic safety;
- transportation; and
- contacting emergency services.

Do not improvise medical treatment, restraint, emergency transport, medication administration, or rescue techniques outside your training and assigned role.

Aquatic and specialized-activity boundaries

Being able to organize a pool party, beach outing, fitness activity, hike, sport, or adventure program does not make you the qualified safety professional for that activity.

Where an employer requires lifeguards, instructors, coaches, guides, drivers, first-aid responders, or other credentialed specialists, use those professionals and follow their authority. Do not accept a specialized duty merely because staffing is short if you lack the required training or authorization.

Safeguarding children and vulnerable participants

Programs serving children, older adults, people with disabilities, or other vulnerable participants may have background-check, screening, supervision, safeguarding, or mandatory-reporting requirements.

Your role is to follow the approved protocol. This may include:

- keeping required participant ratios;
- avoiding prohibited one-to-one situations;
- using approved communication channels;
- reporting observed or disclosed concerns promptly;
- recording facts rather than speculation;
- contacting the designated safeguarding lead or authority; and
- preserving privacy while recognizing that some concerns cannot legally remain confidential.

Do not conduct your own investigation unless that duty is formally assigned to a qualified role.

Accessibility and disability inclusion

Recreation programs should be planned so people with disabilities can participate meaningfully where the program can reasonably support them.

Depending on the setting, this may involve:

- accessible routes and venues;
- adapted schedules or participation methods;
- captioning, interpretation, or communication support;
- accessible digital registration and program information;
- sensory considerations;
- adaptive equipment used according to training;
- clear accommodation-request procedures;
- respectful person-centered communication; and
- coordination with qualified professionals when an activity involves clinical, rehabilitation, or individualized medical needs.

Inclusive recreation is not the same as recreational therapy. Do not claim clinical rehabilitation authority you do not hold.

Privacy, records, and photography

Recreation programs may handle names, ages, contact details, emergency contacts, disability or health information, consent forms, payment information, attendance, incident reports, background-check information, photographs, and safeguarding records.

Follow employer rules for:

- collecting only necessary information;
- role-based access;
- approved registration and record systems;
- secure sharing;
- retention and disposal;
- photo and media consent;
- factual incident notes;
- private conversations;
- use of personal phones or messaging apps; and
- reporting lost devices, misdirected messages, or unauthorized disclosures.

Do not keep participant lists or photos on a personal device for convenience unless the organization explicitly authorizes and secures that practice.

Cybersecurity basics

Use:

- unique passwords and approved password managers;
- multifactor authentication where available;
- approved devices and software;
- verified payment-change procedures;
- least-privilege access;
- secure handling of registration spreadsheets and participant rosters;
- caution with QR codes, event links, attachments, and shared drives;
- independent confirmation of unusual vendor or executive requests; and
- prompt reporting of suspicious messages, account activity, or lost equipment.

Never bypass security controls because registration is busy or an event deadline is close.

Using AI responsibly

AI can help with low-risk tasks such as:

- brainstorming generic activity themes;
- creating draft supply checklists;
- improving plain-language program descriptions;
- generating generic icebreakers;
- drafting non-sensitive calendar text;
- practicing interview questions; and

- suggesting survey questions for human review.

Do **not** paste confidential participant, child, health, disability, safeguarding, emergency-contact, payment, employee, volunteer, or unpublished organizational information into a public AI service unless the organization has specifically approved that system and the data use.

Human review is required. Verify activity instructions, age appropriateness, safety information, accessibility language, dates, costs, translations, names, rules, eligibility statements, and commitments before use.

AI is not a substitute for emergency procedures, professional judgment, safeguarding decisions, medical advice, therapeutic planning, lifeguard authority, coaching credentials, accessibility decisions, or management approval.

A practical 12-week start plan

Weeks 1-2: Review 15-20 local job postings. Record recurring requirements for schedule, participant population, education, driving, background checks, CPR/first aid, physical demands, software, and languages.

Weeks 3-4: Build core program skills: calendars, sign-in records, activity setup, customer service, group communication, supply tracking, and basic spreadsheets.

Weeks 5-6: Learn local recreation resources and practice planning accessible, low-risk activities with clear objectives, supplies, staffing, backup plans, and escalation points.

Weeks 7-8: Complete suitable public or employer-recognized training in safety, first aid/CPR where relevant, safeguarding, accessibility, conflict de-escalation, privacy, cybersecurity, or event coordination.

Weeks 9-10: Build supervised experience through municipal programs, community centers, camps, schools, senior programs, disability-inclusive recreation, sports, arts, nonprofits, or community events.

Weeks 11-12: Apply to roles that match your actual training and experience. Prepare examples showing reliable activity delivery, participant service, safety awareness, documentation, teamwork, inclusion, problem solving, and appropriate escalation.

Building experience without already having the title

Transferable experience can come from:

- customer service;
- volunteering;

- event setup and coordination;
- camps;
- sports or arts programs;
- school clubs;
- senior programs;
- disability-inclusive community programs;
- hospitality;
- tourism;
- libraries and cultural organizations;
- youth organizations;
- municipal programs;
- faith-based or nonprofit programs; and
- administrative support.

Describe your experience precisely. Useful evidence can include reliable attendance, safe activity setup, accurate participant records, improved registration flow, volunteer scheduling, accessible materials, reduced supply waste, successful events, participant satisfaction, or prompt incident escalation.

Do not claim clinical, teaching, childcare, lifeguard, coaching, management, or safeguarding-investigation authority you did not have.

Career progression

Possible next steps may include senior recreation leader, activities coordinator, recreation coordinator, program specialist, community recreation coordinator, volunteer coordinator, events coordinator, camp supervisor, parks and recreation supervisor, senior-living activities director, or program manager.

Progression depends on sector, education, experience, staff and budget responsibility, population served, safety credentials, regulated-profession boundaries, and employer requirements. Time in a frontline role does not automatically qualify someone for a protected professional title or management position.

Verify before you enroll or accept a job

Before paying for training or accepting a position, verify:

- the actual duties;
- participant age and population;
- reporting line;
- staff or volunteer supervision;
- schedule, evenings, weekends, holidays, and seasonal status;

- outdoor and physical demands;
- background or screening requirements;
- CPR, first-aid, aquatic, coaching, fitness, driving, or other certifications;
- safeguarding obligations;
- accessibility responsibilities;
- privacy and photography rules;
- transportation duties;
- budget or purchasing authority;
- compensation and contract type;
- whether the role is temporary, seasonal, grant-funded, or permanent; and
- what training and insurance the employer provides.

Get important promises in writing.

Controlled source list

1. O*NET OnLine — Recreation Workers, 39-9032.00
[Source link](#)
2. O*NET OnLine — Recreation Workers details
[Source link](#)
3. O*NET OnLine — National wages, Recreation Workers
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7. Government of Canada Job Bank — Recreation Program Leader summary, NOC 54100
[Source link](#)
8. Government of Canada Job Bank — NOC 54100 national wages
[Source link](#)
9. SENA Betowa — Liderazgo en la actividad deportiva y la recreación
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10. Bogotá Secretaría de Cultura, Recreación y Deporte — Convenio SCRD-SENA / 2026 training call
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12. SENA — 2026 sports-program technical-learning news
[Source link](#)
13. OIT/Cinterfor — Regional professional-training statistics observatory
<https://www.cinterfor.org/statsfp>
14. CareerOneStop — WIOA-Eligible Training Program Finder
[Source link](#)
15. CareerOneStop — American Job Center Finder
[Source link](#)
16. CareerOneStop — Find Training
[Source link](#)
17. Apprenticeship.gov — Apprenticeship Finder
[Source link](#)

Assurance boundary

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